



Government of the People, by the People, for the People

FOCUS

TERMS TO KNOW

civics, citizen, government, dictatorship, democracy, representative democracy

OBJECTIVES

- Discuss the basic **purposes of government.**
- Identify various **levels of government.**
- Explain the difference between **dictatorship and democracy.**
- Describe **two kinds of democracy.**
- Discuss **how citizens influence government.**

Civics is the study of citizenship and government. The word comes from the Latin word *civis*, meaning "citizen." In ancient Rome, where the word was first used, only wealthy landowners were allowed to be citizens. As such, they enjoyed special privileges that the common people did not share. Today the word *citizen*—a member of a community with a government and

laws—applies to most people. Wealth and property are no longer requirements for citizenship.

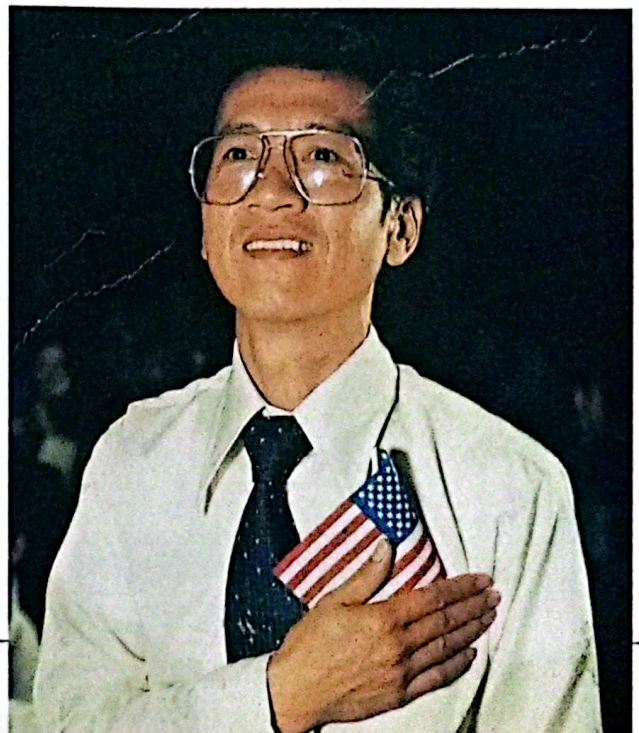
Being a citizen means much more than just living in a country. American citizens who live abroad are still citizens of the United States. Similarly, many foreigners living in this country remain citizens of their own countries.

Being a citizen means being a part of a country or community. Citizens usually share a common history, common customs, and common values. They agree to abide by a set of rules and to accept the government's authority.

The Purposes of Government

Government, the power or authority that rules a country, is an essential part of every nation and of many communities. It provides the stability that makes many things we take for granted possible. A government makes laws, provides services, and keeps order.

Citizenship A new citizen recites the Pledge of Allegiance for the first time. *What rights do you think a citizen has?*



The Need for Government

To understand why having a government is important, imagine living without one. Without government, how would disagreements between individuals, groups, or nations be settled? Disputes between individuals, for example, might be settled by fighting or arguing. The stronger or smarter person—not necessarily the “right” person—would most likely win. Rules help protect us from others, bring order to our lives, and help us live together peacefully.

Without government, imagine how much more difficult your life would be in other ways. Traveling would be difficult because there would be few roads. Those that did exist would be owned by people who could afford to build them.

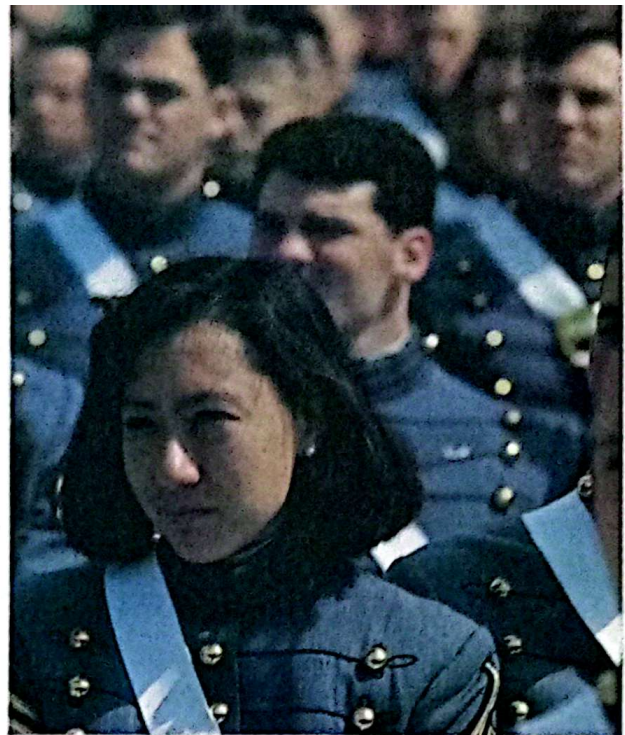
The Earliest Governments

Every society needs rules and some form of government. It is likely that people learned this lesson very early. The earliest writings known—from the ancient Sumerians—show that people had set up formal governments more than 5,000 years ago.

What Governments Do

Ancient governments served much the same purposes that modern governments serve today. The most important purpose of a government is to provide laws, or rules of conduct. These laws help prevent conflicts between individuals, groups, or nations and help settle any conflicts that do occur. By using laws, a government establishes order and provides security for its citizens.

Governments not only make laws, but also make sure that people obey the laws. Almost every country in history,



Roles of Government Training young men and women, like these West Point cadets, to serve in the armed forces is one role of government. *What are some of its other roles?*

for example, has had laws against stealing. When people know they will be punished if they take someone else's property, they are less likely to steal.

In general, judges and courts, which are a part of government, settle conflicts. If one person accuses another of stealing, but the accused person denies the charge, a court determines who is telling the truth. Then, the judge orders an appropriate punishment, if necessary.

In addition to providing and enforcing laws, governments serve many other purposes. They set up armed services, police forces, and fire departments to protect their citizens. They provide services such as education, health facilities, and road construction that most individuals would not be able to provide for themselves. Governments also plan for the future of their country by setting goals, making budgets, and cooperating with other governments.

Levels of Government

Many levels of government exist, each representing a particular collection of people. Each of the 50 states in the United States has its own government; so do most counties, cities, and towns. The students in your school may have their own student government.

National Government

Although each of these is a government, when most people talk about "the government" they are talking about the *national* government—the government of an entire country. A national government is different from other levels of government in two important ways.

First, a national government has the highest level of authority over its citizens. A city or state government, for example, cannot make any laws that would go against the laws of the national government. The national government, however, has the power to make whatever laws it feels would benefit the country. Second, a national government provides the basic framework for citizenship.

Citizenship

Being a citizen of a nation means that you share a history and a set of beliefs with the rest of the country's citizens. Americans, for example, share the ideals of individual rights and equality of opportunity. These ideals are expressed in many of our nation's most important documents, and time and again Americans have fought when necessary to uphold these ideals. The shared beliefs and history are a part of the heritage of all American citizens, whether they were born here or became citizens after settling here.

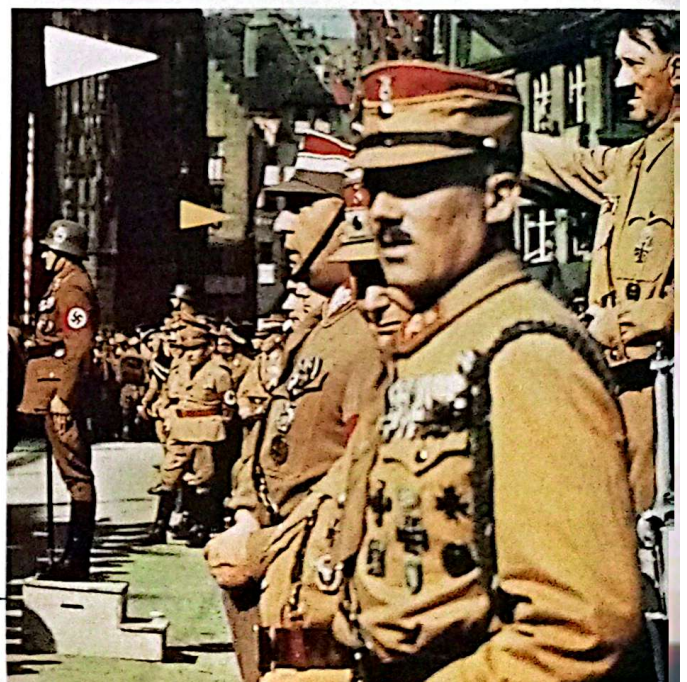
Dictatorship and Democracy

Nearly 200 countries exist in the world today. Each has its own history and beliefs and its own form of government. In many countries, the power of the national government is in the hands of a very small group of people—or sometimes of just a single person.

A government that one person or a small group of people controls is called a **dictatorship**. The leader or leaders of a dictatorship have complete control over the laws and government of the country, and thus over the lives of its citizens. Often, the citizens are told where to live, what kind of work to do, and what political beliefs to have. They may not be allowed to travel to other countries.

Throughout the ages, there have been many dictatorships. Kings, conquerors, and other powerful leaders have controlled their countries completely and often ruled by force. More than 2,000 years ago in ancient Greece, however, the citizens of the city of Athens established

Dictatorship Adolf Hitler ruled Germany as a dictator from 1933 to 1945. *Why do you think dictators need large armies?*



Teaching

Have you ever thought about what it is like to be a teacher? A teacher's job is to help students learn about different subjects and learn to think and express themselves clearly. In elementary school, teachers spend all day with the same group of students, teaching them several subjects. In junior high and high school, teachers do just the opposite. They teach the same subject—social studies, for example—to different groups of students all day long. Teachers who work in colleges and universities also specialize in one subject.

Vocational teachers are another type of teacher. They often work for vocational

schools or labor unions, teaching students how to perform a specific skill, such as repairing cars or operating a computer.

Outside Work

Teachers spend a great deal of time working outside the classroom. They prepare lesson plans, grade exams and papers, take courses, and attend meetings. They also confer with parents or help with after-school activities.



Preschool teacher

Qualifications

To become a teacher, you usually must be a college graduate. Many schools also require advanced degrees. You must like young people and have a great deal of patience.

CAREER REVIEW

- 1 How is teaching in an elementary school different from teaching in a high school or college?
- 2 What do you think are some of the rewards and some of the disadvantages of teaching?

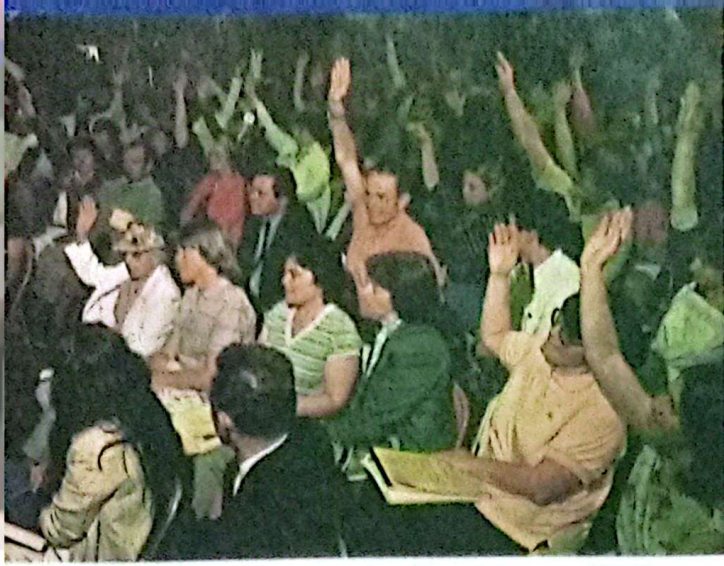
a different type of government called democracy. In a **democracy**, the citizens hold the power to rule and to make the laws.

Two Kinds of Democracy

The government the ancient Athenians set up was a "direct democracy," in which every adult male citizen participated directly. When laws needed to be made or leaders chosen, the citizens

would meet to debate and vote on every issue.

Because modern countries are generally much larger than ancient Athens, direct democracy is no longer a practical way to run a national government. Instead, in many countries, including the United States, citizens elect representatives to govern on their behalf. In a **representative democracy**, the citizens' representatives carry on the work of government.



Democracy in Action Town meetings in New England give local residents a chance to express their views on community issues. *How else do citizens express their views?*

In large modern nations, a government of elected representatives can work more efficiently than a direct democracy. Nevertheless, the power to govern still comes from the citizens. In a representative democracy, the citizens are the final source of authority.

How Citizens Influence Government

The United States government is one of the oldest democracies in the world. For more than 200 years, the people of the United States have used their power and authority to influence their government. They have done this in various ways.

Each American citizen has the right to elect representatives to the national government, including senators, members of the House of Representatives, a President, and a Vice President. As representatives of the people, these leaders have the responsibility to listen to the opinions of voters, whether expressed in person, by mail, by phone, or through public opinion polls.

Americans also have other ways to make themselves heard and influence their government. By joining a political party, they can help decide who will run for office and help plan for the country's future. By joining with other citizens who share similar viewpoints about a particular issue, they can get the government and other Americans to listen.

Abraham Lincoln, America's sixteenth President, described the United States as a "government of the people, by the people, for the people." Lincoln's words make three important points about American democracy. First, the power of the government comes from the people. Second, the American people themselves, acting through their representatives, run their government. Third, the purpose of the government is to make the United States a better place for the people who live there.

★ SECTION 1 REVIEW ★

UNDERSTANDING VOCABULARY

Define civics, citizen, government, dictatorship, democracy, representative democracy.

REVIEWING OBJECTIVES

- 1 What are the basic purposes of government?
- 2 What are some of the different levels of government?
- 3 What is the difference between a dictatorship and democracy?
- 4 What are two kinds of democracy?
- 5 How can American citizens influence their government?